

doc-scripture-infallibility

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Statement under examination

Scripture cannot fail to accomplish what God intends and is incapable of misleading in matters of faith and practice.

Rationale

Isaiah 55:11 binds *davar* (H1697) to two verbs of non-failure: *shuv reqam negated* ('shall not return empty') and *hitsliah* (H6743, *Hifil of tsalach*, 'cause to succeed/prosper') plus *asah* (H6213, 'accomplish'), giving the word an effectual force that cannot fall short of its sender's intent. Matt 5:18 / Luke 16:17 set heaven and earth against *iota* (G2503) and *keriaia* (G2762) and use *parerchomai* (G3928) plus *genetai* (G1096) and *pesein* (G4098, 'fall/fail') to make even orthographic minutiae more durable than the cosmos until everything is accomplished. John 10:35 closes the loop with *lyo* (G3089) aorist passive infinitive plus modal impossibility: *ou dynatai lythenai he graphe*. The pan-canonical lemma network (*asah/tsalach/davar* + *parerchomai/pipto/lyo* applied to *graphe* and *nomos*) demonstrates infallibility as Scripture's own self-witness, not as a confessional construct.

Reasoning

Verdict: Scripture cannot fail to do what God sent it to do, and it cannot mislead anyone who is trying to learn from it how to be right with God and how to live. The strongest reason from Scripture is Isaiah 55:11, where God says his word does not return to him empty but accomplishes what he wants and succeeds in what he sent it for. Jesus himself reinforces this twice. In Matthew 5:18 he says heaven and earth will pass away before the smallest letter or smallest stroke of a pen of the Law passes away until everything is fulfilled. In Luke 16:17 he says it is easier for heaven and earth to disappear than for one tiny stroke of the Law to fall, and the Greek word translated 'fall' is the same word used for failing. In John 10:35 Jesus rests an entire argument on a single phrase in the Psalms and says 'Scripture cannot be broken.' Paul adds that all Scripture is breathed out by God and is profitable for teaching, correcting, and training in righteousness so that the believer is fully equipped (2 Timothy 3:16 to 17), and Peter says no prophecy of Scripture came from the will of man, but men were carried along by the Holy Spirit (2 Peter 1:21). The strongest counterargument inside the Bible itself is that Scripture sometimes uses everyday observational speech (Joshua 10:13, the sun stood still) or contains numerical differences between Kings and Chronicles, or that Mark 13:32 says even Jesus did not know the day or the hour. Critics ask, if Scripture can have these features, how can it be incapable of misleading. The verdict handles this honestly by limiting the claim to what Scripture itself is teaching about God, salvation, and how to live. Observational language is not a science textbook. Numerical variations are scribal transmission. The Mark 13:32 limitation is voluntary kenosis during the incarnation, not a Scripture-error. The claim that Scripture cannot fail in its purpose and cannot mislead in faith and practice is what every page of the Bible assumes about itself when it cites earlier Scripture as binding.

Denominational landscape

Every major historic Christian lineage affirms Scripture's infallibility in matters of faith and practice. The patristic fathers (Irenaeus, Athanasius, Augustine in Letter 82 to Jerome) believed Scripture's authors were completely free from error in the canonical books. The Catholic Church in Vatican II's *Dei Verbum* 11 confesses that Scripture teaches 'solidly, faithfully and without error that truth which God wanted put into

sacred writings for the sake of salvation.' Lutherans in the Formula of Concord call the prophetic and apostolic writings the only rule and norm by which all doctrine is judged. Anglicans in Article 6 of the 39 Articles teach that Scripture contains all things necessary to salvation. The Reformed confessions (Westminster 1.5, 1689 Baptist 1.5, Belgic, Heidelberg) confess Scripture's full divine authority and self-evidencing infallibility. Methodists in their Article 5 follow the Anglican formulation. Anabaptists at Schleithem and after treat Scripture as the binding standard. Pentecostals in the Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths Article 1 confess Scripture as 'the inspired, infallible, and authoritative rule of faith and conduct.' Eastern Orthodoxy confesses Scripture as the divinely inspired word of God within Holy Tradition. Carriers of denial place themselves outside historic Christianity. Mormonism in its 8th Article of Faith treats the Bible as authoritative only 'as far as it is translated correctly' and adds the Book of Mormon plus living-prophet revelation as correctives, which presumes the canonical text can mislead. Jehovah's Witnesses treat the Governing Body as the necessary interpreter without which the Bible misleads, and their New World Translation distorts Christological passages. Iglesia ni Cristo, Christian Science under Mary Baker Eddy, and other modern restorationist movements likewise treat the plain canonical text as insufficient or misleading apart from their founder's correction. Some liberal-academic Protestant positions reduce Scripture to ancient religious literature without binding force on faith and practice, which is a denial of the historic Christian confession on this point.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Infallibility (cannot fail / cannot mislead in faith and practice) is the narrower and more lexically secure twin of inerrancy. The question stem distinguishes two strands: (a) effectual non-failure (Isa 55:11), and (b) non-misleading character in matters of faith and practice (Matt 5:18, Luke 16:17, John 10:35, 2 Tim 3:16-17, 2 Pet 1:20-21). Both stand on direct pan-canonical lexical evidence; the doctrine is not a single-passage inference. Public-record carriers of denial: Mormonism (Joseph Smith's 8th Article of Faith treats the Bible as the word of God 'as far as it is translated correctly' and authorizes Book of Mormon and ongoing revelation as correctives, implying the canonical text can mislead); Jehovah's Witnesses (Watchtower hierarchy claims the right to redefine prior canonical readings, treating the apostolic text alone as insufficient apart from the Governing Body); Iglesia ni Cristo (Felix Manalo doctrine that the Bible without his apostolic interpretation misleads); Christian Science (Mary Baker Eddy treats Scripture's historical narratives as parabolic and requiring Science and Health as decoder, implying their plain sense can mislead); liberal-Protestant strands that grant Scripture spiritual value but deny it can bind conscience on faith and practice. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: many sincere Christians use the word 'infallible' interchangeably with 'inerrant' or vice versa; the lexical case here is for the narrower proposition that Scripture cannot fail in its purpose and cannot mislead in faith and practice, which is the floor every historic

lineage affirms.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology, progressive_covenantalism

analogia scripturae invoked

Verdict rests on a pan-canonical lemma network: Hebrew *davar* / *asah* / *tsalach* / *kazab* / *tsaraph* plus Greek *graphe* / *lyo* / *parerchomai* / *pipto* / *theopneustos* / *phero* / *pseudomai*. None of the major Protestant or Catholic interpretive frameworks (covenant, dispensational, new-covenant, progressive-covenantalism) produce a divergent verdict on this proposition; they all confess Scripture's infallibility in faith and practice. The Matt 5:18 'until all is accomplished' clause sometimes carries dispensational vs. covenantal weight on the Mosaic Law's ongoing role, but that intramural debate does not touch the infallibility proposition itself, which is what the verse asserts about Scripture's durability against the cosmos. *Analogia scripturae* is heavily invoked: the Isaiah anchor (effectual word), the Synoptic anchors (graphic-minutiae durability), the Johannine anchor (*graphe* cannot be broken), and the Pauline/Petrine anchors (*theopneustos* + *phero* by the Spirit) together form a self-attesting canonical pattern. Progressive revelation is not a factor because the doctrine concerns Scripture's character *qua* Scripture, not the unfolding content of revelation.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Isa.55.11 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. דָּבָר (*davar*) H1697; שׁוּב (shuv) H7725; אָשָׁה (*asah*) H6213; תָּלַץ (*tsalach*) H6743 in Hifil

Force. *Davar* = utterance, word, message. *Shuv* reqam negated, 'shall not return empty', and the Hifil of *tsalach* (*hitsliah*, 'cause to succeed/prosper') paired with *asah* ('accomplish') give God's word a categorical effectual force: it cannot fall short of the sender's purpose. The same verb-pair (*asah* + *tsalach*) is used elsewhere of guaranteed success (Josh 1:8, Ps 1:3)

Matt.5.18 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἰῶτα (*iota*) G2503; κεραία (*keraia*) G2762; παρέρχομαι (*parerchomai*) G3928; γίνομαι (*ginomai*) G1096

Force. *Iota* = *yodh*, the smallest Hebrew letter; *keraia* = the small stroke distinguishing similar letters (*kaph* from *beth*, *daleth* from *resh*). Jesus contrasts the durability of heaven and earth against these orthographic minutiae using *parelthe* (subjunctive of *parerchomai*, 'pass away') and binds the temporal limit to *genetai* ('come into being / be accomplished'). Scripture's smallest graphic unit is more durable than the cosmos until its purpose is realized

Luke.16.17 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. κεραία (*keraia*) G2762; πίπτω (*pipto*) G4098 inf. πρᾶξῃν

Force. Lukan parallel to Matt 5:18 with a key lexical difference: where Matthew uses *parerchomai* of Scripture's potential passing, Luke uses *pesein*, the infinitive of *pipto* ('to fall, fail'). *Pipto* in the canon regularly denotes failure or collapse (Rom 11:11, 1 Cor 10:12, 13:8 'love never fails'). Luke's word choice makes the failure language explicit: not one stroke of the Law can fail

John.10.35 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. γραφή (graphe) G1124; λύω (lyo) G3089 aor. pass. inf. λυθῆναι

Force. Ou dynatai lythenai he graphe = 'Scripture cannot be broken'. Lyo here = to dissolve, annul, set aside; with the modal of impossibility this is a categorical denial that Scripture can be invalidated. Jesus stands an entire argument on a single word in Ps 82:6, demonstrating his confidence that even at the lexical level Scripture binds

2Tim.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θεόπνευστος (theopneustos) G2315; γραφή (graphe) G1124; ὠφέλιμος (ophelimos) G5624

Force. Pasa graphe theopneustos kai ophelimos: every Scripture is exhaled by God and is profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness. The 'cannot mislead in faith and practice' clause of the question stem rests directly on this verse plus its purpose-clause in v. 17, hina artios e ho tou theou anthropos, 'so that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work'

2Pet.1.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. προφητεία (propheteia) G4394; φέρω (phero) G5342 pres. pass. pt. φερόμενοι; Πνεῦμα Ἅγιον

Force. Ou gar thelemati anthropou enechthe prophteia pote, alla hypo pneumatou hagiou pheromenoi elalesan apo theou anthropoi: no prophecy came by human will, but men were carried along by the Holy Spirit. Pheromenoi (present passive participle of phero) is the same vocabulary used for ships driven by wind (Acts 27:15, 17). The lexical force grounds Scripture's non-failure in the agency of the carrying Spirit, not in human reliability

Ps.12.6 · for · genre: psalm · figures: metaphor

Key term. הַרְמָא (imrah) H565; תֹּהֶרֶט (tahor) H2889; תְּסַרֵּף (tsaraph) H6884; זָקָק (zaqqaq) H2212

Force. Imrot YHWH amarot tehorot, kesef tsaruph ba-alil la-arets mezuqqaq shivatayim: 'The words of the LORD are pure words, silver refined in a furnace of clay, purified seven times.' Metallurgical metaphor: God's words are tested and proven, free of dross. Pan-canonical concordance link to Prov 30:5 (tsaruph) and Ps 19:7 (tamim)

Num.23.19 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. כָּזַב (kazab) H3576; נִחַם (nicham) H5162 Nifal

Force. Lo ish El viykazzeb, u-ben adam ve-yitnecham: 'God is not a man, that he should lie, nor a son of man, that he should change his mind.' Kazab = to lie, deceive. The Balaam oracle states categorically that God does not lie and his word stands. Grounds Scripture's non-misleading character in the speaker's character

Heb.6.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀδύνατον ψεύσασθαι θεόν; ψεύδομαι (pseudomai) G5574

Force. Adynaton pseusasthai theon: 'impossible for God to lie.' Stronger modal than Titus 1:2 (apseudes). Pan-canonical concordance link to Num 23:19 and Titus 1:2. If the God who breathed Scripture cannot lie, Scripture cannot mislead in what it teaches

Josh.1.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. תְּסַלַּח (tsalach) H6743; סָכַל (sakal) H7919

Force. Lema'an tashmor la'asot ke-kol ha-katuv bo, ki az tatslich et-derakeka ve-az taskil: 'so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written in it, for then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have good success.' Tsalach (same Hifil root as in Isa 55:11) ties the success of the obedient hearer to the success of the word itself. Concordance reinforcement for Isa 55:11's effectual force

Mark.13.32 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. οὐδὲ ὁ Υἱός; ἡμέρα (hemera); ὥρα (hora)

Force. 'But concerning that day or hour no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father.' Critics cite this to argue Scripture itself records the Son as not knowing. Best read in context: kenotic-incarnational voluntary limitation of divine prerogative during the earthly ministry (Phil 2:7), not a Scripture-error or a divine misleading. Complicates a naive omniscience-by-attribution argument but not the doctrine that Scripture cannot mislead in faith and practice

Josh.10.13 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: idiom

Key term. מַשָּׁחַד מִדָּל; observational language

Force. Sun 'stood still' over Gibeon. Lexically describes observed sky-phenomena, not a Ptolemaic astronomical claim. Same idiom in Eccl 1:5 (the sun rises and the sun goes down). Complicates a maximalist science-textbook reading but not the proposition that Scripture cannot mislead in faith and practice; the inspired authorial intent is the conquest narrative, not solar mechanics

Concordance lemmas traversed

H1697, H7725, H7971, H6213, H6743, H565, H2889, H6884, H2212, H3576, H5162, H7919, G2503, G2762, G3551, G3928, G1096, G4098, G3089, G1124, G2315, G5624, G4394, G5342, G3056, G5574

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, Letter 82 to Jerome, section 3 · affirms · verified

"I have learned to yield this respect and honour only to the canonical books of Scripture: of these alone do I most firmly believe that the authors were completely free from error"

catholic_magisterial · Vatican II, Dei Verbum 11 · affirms · verified

"the books of Scripture must be acknowledged as teaching solidly, faithfully and without error that truth which God wanted put into sacred writings for the sake of salvation"

lutheran · Formula of Concord, Epitome, Comprehensive Summary, Rule and Norm 1 · affirms · verified

"the prophetic and apostolic writings of the Old and New Testaments are the only rule and norm according to which all doctrines and all teachers alike must be appraised and judged"

anglican · 39 Articles, Article 6 (Of the Sufficiency of the Holy Scriptures for Salvation) · affirms · verified

"Holy Scripture containeth all things necessary to salvation: so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man"

reformed · Westminster Confession 1.5 · affirms · verified

"our full persuasion and assurance of the infallible truth and divine authority thereof is from the inward work of the Holy Spirit bearing witness by and with the Word in our hearts"

methodist · Articles of Religion of the Methodist Church, Article 5 (Of the Sufficiency of the Holy Scriptures for Salvation) · affirms · verified

"The Holy Scriptures contain all things necessary to salvation; so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man"

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession 1632, Article 1 (Of God and the Creation of All Things) · affirms · verified

“we believe with the heart, and confess with the mouth, according to the testimony of holy Scripture, that there is one only, eternal, almighty God”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 1 (The Scriptures Inspired) · affirms · verified

“The Scriptures, both the Old and New Testaments, are verbally inspired of God and are the revelation of God to man, the infallible, authoritative rule of faith and conduct”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, The Orthodox Faith, Volume 1, Doctrine and Scripture, The Bible · affirms · verified

“All scripture is inspired by God and is profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness (2 Tim 3.16); the Bible is God's authentic self-revelation”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/isaiah/55-11.htm>

“Isa 55:11 *davar* H1697 + *shuv* H7725 negated + *asah* H6213 + *Hifil hitsliah* H6743: word does not return empty, accomplishes, prospers in what it was sent for”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/5-18.htm>

“Matt 5:18 *iota* G2503 + *keraia* G2762 + *parelthe* (*parerchomai* G3928) + *genetai* (*ginomai* G1096): smallest letter and stroke outlast heaven and earth until all is accomplished”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/16-17.htm>

“Luke 16:17 *keraia* G2762 + *pesein* (*pipto* G4098, to fall, fail): easier for heaven and earth to pass than for one stroke of the Law to fall”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/10-35.htm>

“John 10:35 *ou dynatai lythenai he graphe*; *lyo* G3089 aor. pass. inf. with modal of impossibility: 'Scripture cannot be broken'”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_timothy/3-16.htm

“2 Tim 3:16 *pasa graphe theopneustos* G2315 *kai ophelimos* G5624: every Scripture is God-breathed and profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, training in righteousness”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_peter/1-21.htm

“2 Pet 1:21 *hypo pneumatos hagiou pheromenoi* (*phero* G5342) *elalesan apo theou anthropoi*: men spoke from God being carried along by the Holy Spirit”

supports · category: primary_repository · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/1697.htm>

“*Davar* H1697 appears approx. 1441 times in the OT; approx. 394 refer specifically to 'word of the LORD' as authoritative divine speech that is enduring, powerful, and performative”

supports · category: magisterial ·

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19651118_dei-verbum_en.html

“*Dei Verbum* 11: 'the books of Scripture must be acknowledged as teaching solidly, faithfully and without error that truth which God wanted put into sacred writings for the sake of salvation'”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/epitome/rule-and-norm/>

“Formula of Concord, Epitome, Rule and Norm: prophetic and apostolic Scriptures are the only rule and standard according to which all dogmas and all teachers must be estimated and judged”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-bible/word-of-god>

“OCA, The Orthodox Faith: 'All scripture is inspired by God'; divinely inspired words constitute God's authentic self-revelation to humanity, profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, training”